THE LEDGER ROOM

An Original Screenplay

Story Factory demonstration -- AI-authored draft

Demonstration draft -- 20 October 2026

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FADE IN:

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- TUESDAY MORNING

CLARA VENN, 54, puts a saucer under a cabinet leg. The cabinet stops rocking. She removes a receipt from the saucer, reads it, files it.

Outside the high windows: gulls. Inside: twenty-seven years of municipal paper, sorted for a journey nobody wants to make. A sign says PUBLIC READING ROOM. Someone has crossed out PUBLIC.

TOM KEST, 60, wheels in a trolley with one square wheel.

TOM
They've taken the kettle.

CLARA
It's an electrical appliance. It went yesterday.

TOM
It had water in it.

CLARA
Then they've taken the reservoir too.

He presents a crate. Clara checks the six-digit seal against a book, not against the label. He waits with the practiced patience of a man who will wait no longer after Thursday.

TOM
My last box.

CLARA
Your last ordinary box. We still have exceptions.

TOM
I'm not an exception from nine on Thursday.

He puts his pension acceptance form beside the crate. Her signature already sits on it. She shifts the form out of the way before checking the next number.

A delivery horn makes two polite notes, then one thoroughly impolite one. Tom goes. Clara circles a transposed digit in red. Below her hand: TRANSFER COMPLETE, with an empty space for her signature.

EXT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- YARD -- MORNING

A yellow van blocks a contractor's empty skip. JORY SENN, 37, in an oversized courier jacket, is measuring the gate with a bakery ruler.

JORY
Your manifest says vehicle access.

CLARA
You appear to have accessed it.

JORY
Getting out counts extra.

Jory has driven in forward. She considers the tiny turning space. Clara points to a chalk mark on the wall.

CLARA
Rear wheel there. Full left. Stop when you can see the blue door.

Jory tries it. The van turns, cleanly. Clara lifts the gate bolt as Jory comes through.

JORY
You ought to put that on the manifest.

CLARA
Then they'd send a larger van.

Jory hands her a terminal. The screen offers ACCEPT ALL. Clara scrolls down to INDIVIDUAL ITEMS.

JORY
Forty-eight hours. Nine Thursday, keys to the contractor. Nine oh one, I stop existing.

CLARA
Temporary contract?

JORY
Permanent contract conditional on satisfactory closure. They've found a way to make permanence temporary.

Clara signs only for the terminal. Jory watches the small distinction.

JORY
You're the completion signatory?

CLARA
I'm the person who can tell you what's here.

JORY
That's the one I need.

She produces two pairs of gloves. Clara takes one.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- MORNING

LIDA RUSK, 48, municipal transition director, photographs a meter. She has dressed for an office she will not reach today.

LIDA
I can release your bridge payment when the final certificate lands. Not before. Finance have written it in three places.

She gives Clara a thin envelope. Clara puts it in her handbag without opening it.

CLARA
The damp series goes to cold storage. There are thirty-one cartons.

LIDA
Twenty-nine. Two were condemned.

CLARA
By whom?

LIDA
By the paper conservator whose fee you approved.

Clara checks her list. Lida does not enjoy being right.

LIDA
You may visit them in cold storage. You may not move in.

JORY
Would she need a completion certificate?

Lida gives Jory a look, then nearly smiles.

LIDA
Gate keys, water off, electrical isolation, personal property removed. Those are the contractor's conditions. I cannot buy another week's occupation. The flood-reserve audit is Friday. Every loose contract gets closed first.

CLARA
I know what Thursday is.

Lida lays down the demolition-clearance plan. No building collapse, just a new interior for a refrigeration company. The ledger room is to become a loading bay.

LIDA
Good. Because people are counting this money twice already.

She sees the saucer under the cabinet.

LIDA
Is that yours?

CLARA
No. It belongs here.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- LATER

Jory fills crates. Clara reads labels aloud. Their rhythm improves: date, series, seal, thump.

JORY
Why do you keep the empty covers?

CLARA
They say what went missing.

JORY
We call those invoices.

Jory pulls a carton from the cabinet. A thin blue book slides behind it. She catches it with her knee. Clara reaches too late; a brittle slip falls out.

LOW STEPS RELOCATION. FINAL RECONCILIATION. Twenty-three household numbers. Beside each: SETTLED. Clara holds the slip next to the page it marked.

CLARA
Where was that?

JORY
Behind the shelf stop.

On the slip, household 17 is HELD. Under SETTLED, a narrow strip of paper has been pasted over the column. Clara angles it toward the window.

JORY
That's not unusual, is it? People corrected things before computers.

CLARA
Corrections were initialed.

She checks the bottom of the page. Her own neat signature: RECEIVED FOR TRANSMISSION, C. VENN.

JORY
Is it your correction?

CLARA
No.

Clara opens the book wider, pressing on a spine she has spent her career protecting.

JORY
Can I put it in with the rest?

The carton is labeled SCANNED -- DISPOSE. Clara takes the label off.

CLARA
Not that one.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- READING COUNTER -- MIDDAY

BEA QUILL, 69, stands outside the closed counter holding a plastic bag of stair rods. Tom has let her in.

BEA
They said you were selling the furniture.

CLARA
Only municipal furniture.

BEA
Then I want my stair rods back.

She empties the bag: one bent rod and a brass fitting.

BEA
They took the other eleven when they took the stairs. Low Steps. I was told everything would be inventoried. Twelve years is a generous inventory.

Clara puts the blue book below the counter.

CLARA
What number?

BEA
The rods?

CLARA
Your flat.

BEA
Seventeen. We put our names on the doors. That was easier.

Clara checks a public index. It says RELOCATION COMPLETE.

CLARA
Do you have the compensation receipt?

BEA
If I had compensation I'd have bought stairs.

Jory, passing behind Clara, stops.

CLARA
There was a removal allowance.

BEA
There was a van. I signed for a van. I still have the paper because it was a bad van.

CLARA
Could you bring that paper?

BEA
You open until five?

Clara looks at the closure notice taped to the glass.

CLARA
I'll be here.

Bea re-bags her evidence of stairs. She waits for Clara to say why. Clara does not.

INT. COURIER DEPOT -- DISPATCH CAGE -- AFTERNOON

Jory collects flattened cartons. Her phone is wedged between chin and shoulder. Her daughter NELL, 16, speaks through the noise of a school canteen.

NELL (PHONE)
The room has a window.

JORY
Ask if it opens. In the picture it looks painted.

NELL (PHONE)
It's not a prison.

JORY
That wasn't my next question.

Nell sends a rental application. PROOF OF EMPLOYMENT DUE THURSDAY 12:00. Jory enlarges it, then closes it as SANA VELL, 50, dispatcher and union delegate, approaches.

SANA
No more early collections. We lost the school route.

JORY
I'm not early. I'm collecting the boxes for the boxes.

SANA
You've got three of us on that transfer job's retained list. You know that?

JORY
I know I'm one.

Sana gives her a paper rota. Four names have been rubbed away.

SANA
They won't tell us which until it's signed. They say that's flexibility.

Jory folds the rota to hide the erased names.

SANA
Anything wrong down there?

JORY
Someone's pasted paper on paper.

SANA
Isn't that their work?

Jory takes more cartons than she can see over. Sana silently takes half and carries them to the van.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- AFTERNOON

Clara photographs the pasted column with a work camera. Jory returns with the cartons.

JORY
Are you making another copy?

CLARA
I'm recording its condition.

JORY
Same thing with a title.

Clara turns the camera so Jory can see. Pale rectangles. No useful text.

CLARA
The scan has this page. It cannot see underneath. If this goes into pulping, the correction becomes the only version.

JORY
Then put it in an exception box.

CLARA
Exceptions go to cold storage as damaged. Nobody is required to investigate them.

JORY
But they don't get pulped.

Clara considers that adequate answer and finds she cannot use it.

CLARA
I need the payment vouchers. Different series.

JORY
Where?

Clara looks up. A mezzanine of sealed cartons.

JORY
How many?

CLARA
If I knew that, I wouldn't need the vouchers.

Jory removes her jacket. Clara starts to thank her.

JORY
Count it as a collection delay. Not a favor.

Clara writes Jory's start time in the overtime book. Then her own.

INT. CLARA'S FLAT -- KITCHEN -- EVENING

MARA VENN, 27, fills a suitcase with kitchen knives in a rolled cloth. Clara tests a chair that has been sold online.

MARA
Don't sit. The buyer asked if it sags.

CLARA
They all sag if you sit.

Mara adds a tiny kitchen scale. Clara takes out the bridge-payment envelope. Its window shows a sum. She smooths the empty side flat.

MARA
Did you choose the smaller place?

CLARA
I put a holding fee down.

MARA
Good.

CLARA
Don't sound relieved.

MARA
I am relieved. It's eight minutes from the bus. You won't have to keep this place for me.

Clara sees a second train ticket on the table.

CLARA
Who is going with you?

MARA
That's your ticket to the viewing. I bought it before you could decide the bus was fine.

Clara reads it. Wednesday, 14:20.

CLARA
I may have a problem at work.

MARA
You have one day left.

CLARA
Two.

Mara zips the knife roll.

MARA
I'm still leaving Friday. I've told the kitchen. They've made a space for me.

CLARA
I didn't ask you to stay.

MARA
I know. I'm practicing saying it before you need to.

Clara puts the ticket in her envelope. Both women start clearing the same corner of the table. Mara stops first.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- NIGHT

Jory sits on a carton eating cold noodles. Clara climbs down with a voucher file. The depot clock says 20:14.

JORY
My daughter says a noodle is a format, not a dinner.

CLARA
What does she have?

JORY
Noodles in a bowl. Apparently a different format.

Clara opens the file. An empty divider: LOW STEPS -- SUPPLEMENTARY. She pulls the adjacent folder. A carbon sheet clings to its back.

Twenty-three household numbers. Six marked HELD: NO TITLE OR RECEIPT. The bottom carries a staple hole exactly aligned with the blue ledger.

CLARA
There should be six unspent balances.

JORY
How much?

Clara adds figures on an old calculator. It prints nothing. She does it again on paper.

CLARA
Enough that somebody should have asked.

JORY
That's a very flexible amount.

Clara writes a label: DISPUTED SERIES. She signs it. Jory puts down the noodles.

JORY
Does that stop the completion?

CLARA
It means I can't say everything is accounted for.

JORY
You could have told me before I stayed.

Clara has no useful reply. Jory locks the van with a click that carries into the room.

JORY
Tomorrow we find out how much of my work you've stopped.

She leaves. Clara places the carbon beside her own signature and turns on the second lamp.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- COUNTER -- WEDNESDAY MORNING

Clara takes number 004. MINA OLT, 43, the duty registrar, calls 004 to an empty waiting room. Clara approaches.

MINA
You could have stayed there.

CLARA
Then it would have been 005.

Mina recognizes her. She takes the blue book, but Clara keeps a hand on it.

MINA
Do you want to deposit an object or report a discrepancy?

CLARA
The second. Possibly the first.

Mina produces two forms.

MINA
This opens a service complaint. Six weeks for response. This records a disputed transfer. If the records are about to move and you can identify the series and the disputed act.

CLARA
Can it stay where it is?

MINA
No. That building has no receiving custodian after nine tomorrow.

CLARA
You have storage.

MINA
For declared consignments. Not for a whole department's unfinished business. Numbered cartons with an inventory would be a consignment. An office you haven't finished sorting wouldn't.

Mina takes a third form from a drawer. STRONGROOM: DISPUTED TRANSFER. She puts it nearest Clara.

MINA
Owner's release. An inventory we can check without opening private files. A present officer's factual statement explaining why ordinary custody is insufficient.

CLARA
Would that statement stay with the restricted material?

MINA
The names and claim details can. Your act as an officer is an officer record.

Clara looks at her signature in the blue ledger. She closes the book over it.

CLARA
I haven't established what happened.

MINA
Then say what you have established. You don't need an accusation.

CLARA
Can I make a preservation request without the officer statement?

MINA
Not into our strongroom under disputed transfer. You could arrange approved outside custody and submit the discrepancy through the complaint route.

Clara moves the strongroom form back across the counter. Takes the outside-storage conditions. Mina leaves the other form where Clara can still reach it.

MINA
Don't take a private holding arrangement because you expect it to stay private forever. The record can still be called.

CLARA
I'm asking what is permitted.

MINA
And I'm telling you.

She gives Clara the form anyway. There is a space for a named custodian and another for a present records officer's factual statement.

MINA
A disputed transfer can use an outside secure room. It must meet these conditions. It is not a preservation order. You supply custody; I register it.

CLARA
Who decides if the alteration was improper?

MINA
Not me. Not on this form.

Clara reads a line lower down.

CLARA
Responsibility survives the officer's employment.

MINA
That's why people usually bring their manager.

Clara folds the form around the list of storage conditions, carefully leaving the signature line uncreased.

EXT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- YARD -- MORNING

Jory has arranged eighteen crates in the order they must fit the van. Clara enters through the human-sized gap.

JORY
The slot for the disputed book is there. I can finish everything else.

CLARA
That may be possible.

JORY
Possible is a terrible word to load by.

She holds out the terminal. A revised screen: CLEARANCE STATUS -- UNRESOLVED.

JORY
Your label reached dispatch before I did. They took my permanent-contract meeting off the diary.

CLARA
I didn't send them anything.

JORY
It's one system. You put a red thing in it, I get a red thing out.

Clara looks at the screen as if the link is an offensive new invention.

JORY
How many people haven't been paid?

CLARA
Six entries held. I don't know what happened afterward.

JORY
Then you don't know there's a debt.

CLARA
No.

Jory appreciates the answer despite herself.

JORY
I'm not moving a town's debt in a van. I am moving one book. Find somewhere for the book.

She lifts a crate. Clara takes the other handle. They lift it together, poorly; they correct their grip without speaking.

INT. BEA'S FLAT -- FRONT ROOM -- MORNING

A small flat made navigable by fierce arrangement. Bea moves a chair two inches before letting Clara sit. A sewing machine holds a half-finished sail cover.

BEA
Don't put the book there. That's the clean side.

Clara moves the book. Bea sets out a biscuit tin full of papers, organized with hair clips.

CLARA
This one says relocation assistance received.

BEA
Turn it over.

A list on the reverse: ONE VAN, TWO MEN, FOUR HOURS. Bea has added: THREE HOURS TWENTY.

BEA
I was charged for the tea break.

CLARA
Did you object?

BEA
I wrote on the reverse.

Clara hears the rebuke without Bea having to supply it.

CLARA
Your household is marked settled. That may not mean the same thing as paid. I need to establish which.

BEA
And if it means cheated?

CLARA
There may be a review.

BEA
Of what? The word?

Bea hands over a second sheet: a compensation offer contingent on proof of tenancy.

BEA
We had no tenancy papers after the office flooded. They knew that when they offered.

CLARA
May I copy this?

BEA
You can copy mine. Not everybody in that tin lives here.

Clara stops reaching. Bea selects her own sheets, leaving the others under the lid.

BEA
And don't put my address on anything people can come to. I've work to finish.

She takes the sail cover back into her lap. Clara waits until Bea chooses to stand.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- LATE MORNING

Lida places the disputed-transfer form beneath a magnifier. Not to read it. To keep it from Clara.

LIDA
The book can go to the municipal warehouse. Sealed. Normal exception route.

CLARA
As damaged.

LIDA
It is damaged.

CLARA
Somebody changed the column.

LIDA
I can read the column. I can't read somebody.

Clara slides Bea's copied van receipt across. Lida actually reads both sides.

LIDA
The rehousing office had three kinds of allowance. Those households may have taken the assisted move instead of the title payment.

CLARA
Then there will be an election form.

LIDA
Find it. Don't accuse an empty building.

Jory tapes a crate loudly enough to be heard. Lida turns to her.

LIDA
If the ordinary transfer is complete, your supplier can issue an amended completion. The employment decision is theirs.

JORY
Could you put that in writing?

LIDA
The first part.

Jory holds out her pen. Lida writes.

CLARA
Where is the election series?

Lida removes the magnifier.

LIDA
You received it. Your index ought to tell you.

She leaves the form. Clara's search has become an audit of her own work.

INT. COURIER DEPOT -- DISPATCH CAGE -- MIDDAY

Sana reads Lida's note through the wire of the cage. Jory has not yet put it through the slot.

SANA
Let me see the whole thing.

Jory gives it to her. Sana points to AMENDED.

SANA
They promised satisfactory completion. Amended isn't satisfactory until they say it is.

JORY
Then ask.

SANA
I did. They said don't make hypothetical problems.

Jory looks at the rota. Her name appears in pencil now.

JORY
Can we use our secure cage for one ledger?

SANA
We can't keep the insurance envelopes overnight without two signatures.

JORY
It's paper. It won't ask to be insured.

SANA
It's somebody else's paper. That's worse.

A van driver pushes an insurance envelope through the hatch. Sana checks it, signs, waits for the driver to sign, locks it away. Jory watches the entire little ceremony.

JORY
What if someone else insured it?

SANA
Someone can ask dispatch. Not me. I've got nine people asking whether they work Monday.

Jory's phone displays a photograph of Nell beside a college workshop bench. She puts the phone face down before Sana sees the rental reminder below it.

SANA
Don't make a personal guarantee to get a corporate signature. They like that.

Jory takes Lida's note back. She keeps it flat this time.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- MEZZANINE -- AFTERNOON

Clara lifts a ledger from a high shelf while Tom braces the ladder. Jory reads carton numbers below.

JORY
Sixty-two. Sixty-three. Eighty-one.

CLARA
Those are shelf positions, not sequence numbers.

JORY
Of course. It would be absurd to put things next to the things they follow.

Tom laughs. Clara doesn't. Then she laughs, late and short, while the ladder wobbles. All three freeze.

TOM
No enjoyment at height.

Clara gets down. The file contains a dispatch cover dated twelve years earlier: ELECTIONS, LOW STEPS, 23 ATTACHED. No attachments.

JORY
It's your name again.

CLARA
I signed for a sealed envelope.

TOM
We used to get twenty a day. We didn't open everything.

Clara turns the cover over. A checkbox: CONTENTS VERIFIED. Her tick. Beneath it: OUTGOING QUERY RV218. She writes RV218 on her pad.

TOM
That's a request number. Blue weekly register. If it wasn't answered, it'll be in the back.

CLARA
Or struck out in the front.

She puts a finger over her tick. It does not cover the whole box.

JORY
You did open this one.

CLARA
I don't remember.

TOM
Then don't invent remembering.

Clara lays the cover on the book. Jory sees how the pages meet.

JORY
If you hadn't found it, would anybody have asked?

Clara looks at the emptied shelf.

CLARA
No.

Tom takes his hand away from the ladder, then returns it when Clara reaches for the next file.

INT. CLARA'S FLAT -- KITCHEN -- AFTERNOON

Mara is waiting in her coat. Two cups sit on the table. Clara checks the time: 14:09.

MARA
If we walk quickly.

CLARA
I can't go.

Mara takes off her coat. Not dramatically. Just too warm now.

MARA
Then tell the agent.

CLARA
I thought you could.

MARA
No.

Clara puts the disputed-transfer conditions on the table. Mara doesn't read them.

CLARA
Someone may not have been paid for their home.

MARA
Then help them.

CLARA
It's not that simple.

MARA
I didn't say it was. I said you can call the agent yourself.

Clara takes out her phone. Her thumb stays above the screen.

MARA
You do this at work? Make something small wait until it looks cruel to mention it?

CLARA
That's unkind.

MARA
Yes. I've been waiting in a coat.

Clara calls. She turns away, then deliberately turns back.

CLARA
It's Clara Venn. I'm sorry, I can't attend the viewing. No, I understand the fee is nonrefundable.

Mara pours one cup away. Leaves Clara's.

CLARA
I could still use your room until I find somewhere.

MARA
It's your flat.

CLARA
I mean after Friday.

MARA
After Friday too.

Clara looks at the cup. She has mistaken Mara's leaving for permission to leave herself.

EXT. BRIDGE LAYBY -- AFTERNOON

Jory parks beside a closed snack kiosk. Bea waits with her sail cover in a shopping trolley. Below the bridge, a new floodwall protects a row of workshops.

BEA
She sent a van for one sheet?

JORY
She asked me to collect you too.

BEA
That wasn't what she said to me.

Jory checks the message. COLLECT BQ COPY, IF WILLING. She shows Bea.

JORY
Ambiguous cargo. Sorry.

Bea hands over the copied receipt. Keeps the original.

JORY
Did everyone get these? The move forms?

BEA
Some people weren't on the tenancy list. They got nothing to sign.

JORY
Clara has six names.

BEA
Six numbers. It's not the same.

A cyclist rings for passage. Jory moves the van before Bea has to move her trolley.

BEA
One flat had two families. One had a woman who'd taken over her sister's rent. If you make a list of lawful tenants you'll make the rest disappear again.

JORY
I didn't make any list.

BEA
Good. Keep that up.

Bea takes out a folding stool, sits at the kiosk, and begins sewing the cover while she waits for a customer. Jory studies the floodwall. Fresh concrete, expensive and dry.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- LATE AFTERNOON

Jory gives Clara the copy. Then she lifts the clean-completion certificate from under Clara's notebook.

JORY
I can finish the ordinary transfer. Lida said so. Put the book in damaged storage, keep your complaint open, sign the rest.

CLARA
The rest includes a statement that no outstanding rights depend on the disposed records.

JORY
Cross it out.

CLARA
Then it isn't a clean completion.

JORY
You keep using that word as if I chose it.

Clara tries the old calculator. The dead paper mechanism chatters. Jory unplugs it.

While Clara checks the carbon totals, Jory photographs the whole ledger page with her phone: reference at the top, figures in the middle, household names down the edge. She turns the screen to Clara.

JORY
For the delay explanation.

CLARA
The reference can go in the explanation. Not the names.

JORY
I'll crop it.

She locks the phone before making the crop.

JORY
There's a room for Nell near the college. I could do early shifts from there. I've put a deposit down. It comes from having a job that exists next week.

CLARA
I have a payment waiting too.

JORY
Then act like it matters.

Clara takes the certificate. For a moment Jory thinks she has won. Clara draws a line through NO OUTSTANDING RIGHTS. Writes DISPUTED. Initials it.

JORY
You could have done that without telling me why.

CLARA
I did enough of that before.

Jory takes a photograph of the amended sheet, sends it to dispatch, and watches three dots appear. They vanish without a reply.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- LIDA'S OFFICE -- WEDNESDAY EVENING

Lida is eating an apple above a wastebasket. Clara and Jory occupy the visitors' chairs. The window shows the depot roof.

LIDA
The balances were moved to the flood reserve. It was in the accounts.

CLARA
Whose authority?

LIDA
An unclaimed balance is carried for five years. After that it can be reassigned. We carried them for seven.

CLARA
They weren't unclaimed. They were held pending documents the town had lost.

Lida puts the apple down.

LIDA
You think there was a room where someone said, let's take six people's money. There was a room where the engineer said the south wall would not last another winter. I was in that room.

JORY
That's not an answer about the book.

LIDA
No. It isn't.

She opens a finance folder. A typed instruction: CLOSE RELOCATION ACCOUNT -- TRANSFER REMAINING RESERVE.

LIDA
I authorized the transfer. I did not authorize a false receipt.

CLARA
Then support the disputed custody.

LIDA
I can authorize storage. I cannot invent an appropriation, an insurer, a new contract and an answer to six claims tonight.

JORY
We're asking for a cupboard.

LIDA
No. You're asking whose name goes on the cupboard.

She turns the finance instruction so they can copy the reference. Clara writes it down.

LIDA
Take the reference. Don't take the file. I don't want to have this conversation about another one.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- EVENING

Tom has laid clean brown paper on the table for his last supper: three cheese rolls, a jar of pickles, and tea from a flask.

TOM
I stole the reservoir back.

Jory sits immediately. Clara remains standing over the finance index.

TOM
It's not an invitation. It's a meal break.

She sits. Tom puts a roll on her open ledger. She moves it to the brown paper.

JORY
How did Low Steps come in?

TOM
Wet. We hung the covers along that wall. You could read the tenancy names backward through them.

CLARA
I remember the names. I don't remember the envelopes.

TOM
People remember their bit.

Jory offers him a pickle. He declines, takes one, then takes two.

TOM
We had to get every packet entered by year end or the department couldn't close its grant. Clara got it done. They gave her a commendation.

CLARA
It was a letter.

TOM
It went in a frame.

Clara looks toward the empty rectangle on the wall. The frame has already gone home.

JORY
A letter for checking covers?

TOM
For getting the backlog below the grant limit. It was that or send the money back.

CLARA
The department needed it.

TOM
The department. Yes.

He picks a seed out of his roll. Does not look at her.

JORY
What else did you get?

CLARA
A permanent post. I was on rolling cover before that.

JORY
Same condition?

CLARA
It wasn't written that way. The regrading depended on the backlog being closed.

Tom screws the lid on the pickle jar. Clara takes it, unscrews it, puts it back. A small insistence that the meal isn't finished.

CLARA
We all needed the department to stay open.

JORY
I'm not asking about all of you.

Clara takes a bite she cannot answer through. Tom opens his old box.

JORY
Was the envelope sealed?

CLARA
I don't know.

TOM
I said don't invent it. I didn't say never find out.

He opens his own last box. Kept inside: an old receiving-day tally, rescued from a desk drawer. Clara reaches, then stops until Tom passes it to her.

INT. COURIER DEPOT -- DISPATCH CAGE -- EVENING

Jory scans the tally and the amended certificate at the dispatch copier. Her phone rings: OPERATIONS. She answers before the first ring ends.

OPERATIONS (PHONE)
You're not qualified to amend a municipal instruction.

JORY
The signatory amended it. I sent you what she signed.

OPERATIONS (PHONE)
Is this a personal dispute?

JORY
There's an old housing account. Six entries.

OPERATIONS (PHONE)
Send the source. We can ask the client to resolve it.

Jory selects the photograph of the pasted column. Household numbers, amounts, names visible in an adjacent margin. She makes a crop that preserves the figures but cuts off the top reference.

JORY
I'll send the part with the totals.

OPERATIONS (PHONE)
Whole sheet. We can't ask a client to resolve a cropped extract. We need the file reference and signatory.

Jory drags the crop wider. It brings the names back too. She could send two separate details. She looks at the time.

JORY
Can you give me the employment letter if the rest is complete?

OPERATIONS (PHONE)
We can review it when we have the source. We need your carrier condition report as well. Whether the collection is ordinary or excepted is your declaration, not hers.

She holds her thumb above SEND. The copier ejects the rental form she printed earlier. PROOF OF EMPLOYMENT. She cancels the crop and sends the whole photograph.

JORY
It has resident names. I haven't got their permission. You're receiving this to settle the collection, not to contact them.

OPERATIONS (PHONE)
Understood.

JORY
You have it. It's not for circulation.

OPERATIONS (PHONE)
Thanks. No further work outside the written instruction.

The call ends. Sana comes out of the sorting bay with an envelope.

SANA
You need this one witnessed. You look as if you might forget your name.

Jory signs the insurance register. Sana countersigns without looking at the phone.

INT. BEA'S FLAT -- FRONT ROOM -- EVENING

Bea has three phones on the table: hers, an old landline, and a neighbor's with a cracked screen. Clara sits opposite her.

BEA
I called four households. One thinks you've found money. One thinks it's a scam. One said not to use her name. The fourth is dead, so I spoke to her daughter.

CLARA
I didn't ask you to call anyone.

BEA
I know. You asked for papers. I asked people.

She pushes a list across. Six household numbers, no names. Beside one: TWO RENT PAYERS. Another: DO NOT CONTACT AT WORK.

CLARA
I can't promise this will produce a payment.

BEA
Then stop saying it like I asked you to.

Someone knocks twice and opens the door before Bea answers. INA WERR, 44, a woman in a cleaner's tabard under a coat, carries the cracked phone. She puts it on the table.

INA
You said there wouldn't be a picture.

BEA
I didn't send one.

INA
You said it was just to keep a book. Now my sister's number is on someone's work chat.

Clara stands, starts to introduce herself. Ina holds up a hand.

INA
I know which one you are. Were you there when they moved us?

CLARA
I worked in the depot. Not the relocation office.

INA
Then you were there.

Bea pulls out the spare chair. Ina doesn't sit.

BEA
It's the account, Ina. They might have put settled when they meant --

INA
Don't tell me what it might mean. Someone at work asked if I'd been paid twice. I'm not named on that page, but everybody knew which flat was my sister's.

Clara looks at the screen. Two laughing faces beneath the repayment question. Ina takes the phone away before Clara can scroll.

INA
No. You've seen enough of my messages.

CLARA
I'm sorry.

INA
Can you stop the chat?

CLARA
I can ask for the image to be deleted. I can't promise it will stop.

Ina takes the list from the table. Finds twenty-one. The line beside it says TWO RENT PAYERS.

INA
You wrote that?

BEA
It's true.

INA
You don't get to put it in a file because it's true. My sister paid the town. I paid her. If somebody decides that was an illegal sublet, do I get the money or the demand?

CLARA
This process can't decide either.

INA
But it can start one.

Clara does not offer the comforting sentence Ina has just disproved.

BEA
If nobody speaks they'll say there was nobody there. I was trying to keep you from disappearing.

INA
I have a job where people know my name. I haven't disappeared. I just don't want you speaking it to them.

Bea folds her hands in her lap. Then unfolds them.

BEA
You asked me to keep those rent slips.

INA
To keep them.

Bea opens the biscuit tin and takes out a clipped packet. She keeps hold when Ina takes the other end.

BEA
Your niece may want them.

INA
Then she'll ask me.

Bea lets go. Ina puts the packet inside her coat.

CLARA
I won't put your name on a contact list without your authority. The old municipal record still exists. I can't promise to destroy that for you.

INA
I didn't ask you to destroy it. I asked who decides what happens next.

Clara takes a blank sheet. Writes NO CONSENT TO CONTACT. Turns it to Ina without asking her to sign.

CLARA
You decide whether we contact you. You can take this and give it to the registrar yourself. I don't need your address for it.

INA
And Bea?

BEA
I'll take twenty-one off mine.

INA
Not just the name. The story about two rent payers.

Bea crosses the entire entry out. Clara watches the only resident who can corroborate a complication remove it from their organized packet.

Ina checks the clock.

INA
I'm on at seven. I came out of sleep for this. If you hear something I have to do, send it to me in a closed envelope. No calls at work.

CLARA
Yes.

Ina takes her phone, her papers and the unsigned form. At the door she looks back at Bea, almost says something, decides it can wait. She leaves.

Bea sits down. The crossed-out line has cut through a careful column.

BEA
Can the number twenty-one be removed from your photograph?

CLARA
What photograph?

BEA
The one your delivery woman sent. Ina was going to meet her niece after work. Now she has to answer this instead.

Clara looks at the message. A cropped screenshot of the picture Jory took of the ledger. An attached question: DO WE HAVE TO REPAY THIS?

CLARA
Nobody has to repay anything on the basis of that.

BEA
Can you put that back into all the phones?

Clara cannot. Bea takes her list back.

BEA
I need their answers again now. This time they have a different question.

EXT. BRIDGE LAYBY -- DUSK

Jory has pulled over to answer Clara's call. Clara's voice comes through the van speakers while Jory stares at the flooded-concrete expansion joint beneath the bridge.

CLARA (PHONE)
Did you send the list to operations?

JORY
I sent the page that stops my job.

CLARA (PHONE)
It has names on it.

JORY
It has a town's payment column on it. I sent it to the town's contractor.

CLARA (PHONE)
It has reached people outside that chain.

Jory opens her sent message. The full image fills the screen.

JORY
I told them not to circulate it.

CLARA (PHONE)
That isn't permission from the households.

JORY
You put a red label on my contract without permission from mine.

A long silence. Traffic hushes above the van.

CLARA (PHONE)
You're right about that. It doesn't make this right.

JORY
I didn't say it did.

Clara starts to speak. Jory disconnects. She sits through an incoming call from OPERATIONS. Then calls it back.

JORY
Delete the photograph. All copies. Tell me who you forwarded it to.

She listens. Takes out a receipt and starts writing names on the back. Her handwriting gets smaller.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- NIGHT

Lida stands by the cabinet with an email printed in her hand. Clara enters. Jory follows from the yard a few seconds later.

LIDA
Your contractor says the transfer officer has verified a falsified claim schedule.

CLARA
I have not verified a falsified claim.

LIDA
That's what I told them. Now I have to put controls on access.

She lays down a notice: ACCESS SUSPENDED PENDING HANDOVER. Clara looks at Jory. Jory does not move away from the look.

JORY
I said the record was disputed. I didn't say claims were false.

LIDA
They wrote their own sentence. I didn't ask them to.

CLARA
So correct it.

LIDA
I have. The controls remain. A register with private details has circulated outside custody. I have a responsibility for that too.

Clara puts the blue book on the table. Her hand stays on the cover.

CLARA
Your suspension doesn't cancel my records duty.

LIDA
It changes who can authorize your access. You can work with Tom present until midnight. After that the contractor takes isolation control.

TOM
I finish at ten.

All three women look at him.

TOM
I finish at ten. I've told people where I'll be after.

Lida writes 22:00 over MIDNIGHT. Clara watches two hours disappear.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- MEZZANINE -- NIGHT

The receiving-day tally rests beneath a lamp. Clara and Tom read the old entries. Jory loads ordinary crates at the far end, outside the pool of light.

TOM
There. Low Steps. One envelope. Weight thirty-two grams.

CLARA
Twenty-three forms would weigh more.

TOM
Maybe one instruction and a schedule.

Clara gets a blank sheet from a drawer. Puts it on a postal scale. Five grams. She adds sheets, one at a time. Jory stops to watch from the doorway. Six sheets and an envelope reach thirty-two.

CLARA
I checked the cover. I never checked the contents.

TOM
The weight doesn't prove that.

CLARA
No. This does.

Clara takes the blue weekly query register from the carton Tom indicated earlier. The entries run RV201 to RV240. RV218: PLEASE SUPPLY ELECTIONS FOR ATTACHMENT. She follows a ruled line to the response column. Blank. The closure column is signed C. VENN, YEAR END.

An attached sheet lists queries closed in that batch. Clara's certification is one of nineteen. Her hand starts toward the page, stops to put on the gloves.

CLARA
I put it in the completed batch. It wasn't a missing receipt they could follow up. After that it was finished.

TOM
They could have reopened it.

CLARA
They could. I didn't.

She checks the date against her notebook. The week of the regrading. Tom pulls the flask closer, makes himself busy with its cap.

JORY
Is that when they made you permanent?

CLARA
The appointment was confirmed that week.

JORY
You remember that.

CLARA
I remember taking my own key home. Not the spare off the hook. Mine. I kept taking it out of my bag on the bus.

She looks at the key on her present ring. Tom doesn't tell her to stop.

CLARA
I can't remember if I closed this before the letter came or after. I remember that key.

JORY
Did anybody tell you to close it?

CLARA
Not on the record. Not that I can remember.

Jory leans her back against the shelf. No consoling version is offered.

CLARA
If I'd carried the query over, the batch wouldn't have been complete. I'd have been the person with an unfinished list again. I didn't want that.

TOM
Put what you know. Not what you can punish yourself with.

Clara writes two headings on a fresh sheet: RECORD SHOWS. I REMEMBER. Under the first she writes RV218, CLOSED C. VENN. Under the second: THE KEY. She leaves the order of events blank.

TOM
You asked.

CLARA
Then I closed it.

Jory lifts a crate, sets it down without moving it.

JORY
Was there a deadline?

Clara looks toward the amended completion sheet.

CLARA
Yes.

Tom pushes the lamp closer. No one touches her. Clara copies both sides of the leaf, including the part that makes her case worse.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- READING COUNTER -- NIGHT

Bea waits on the visitor's side. Clara brings the copied request. Jory stands by the door, ready to leave if asked.

CLARA
I certified that the papers were there. They weren't. I asked for them, then marked the matter closed. Closing the batch helped secure my permanent post. I can't establish which day the offer came. I know I wanted the post more than I wanted to leave a question open.

Bea looks from the statement to Clara.

BEA
What did you think we'd do?

CLARA
Go back to the housing office.

BEA
It had closed.

Clara puts the duplicate receiving cover beside her statement.

CLARA
I knew that.

BEA
Then where?

Clara cannot manufacture a place she meant them to go.

CLARA
I didn't make myself answer that.

Bea reads the leaf. She looks less surprised than Clara expected.

BEA
I came here three times.

CLARA
I don't remember you.

BEA
You found the rod inventory every time. You were very good at finding it.

Clara sits on the low staff stool. It puts Bea above her.

JORY
I sent the picture to operations. I wanted them to fix the certificate. I gave it to people who don't have a right to decide what happens to your names.

BEA
Yes.

JORY
I've asked for deletion. There's no guarantee.

BEA
No.

Bea folds the copy into her tin.

CLARA
Will you still support disputed custody?

BEA
For the record. Not for a claim in my name. Not yet. And not if you write that all six households agree. They don't.

Clara crosses out a line on her prepared form: AFFECTED RESIDENTS REQUEST. Writes: I REPORT.

BEA
That's a start you can sign.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- NIGHT

The clock reads 21:12. Ordinary transfer crates fill the yard. Tom removes a calendar from a nail. The wall underneath is twelve years cleaner.

JORY
There is a secure cage at dispatch. They use it for insurance documents. Two keys. We could ask for one shelf.

CLARA
I asked Mina. It needs an insured custodian and an access log.

JORY
We have those. Not for this. But we have them.

CLARA
Your manager won't authorize it after today.

JORY
Then we ask the people who'd have to sign.

Clara sees the deletion-request receipt in Jory's hand, covered in names.

CLARA
How many copies?

JORY
Six confirmed. Two forwarded somewhere they won't tell me.

Clara lets the silence go on just long enough to hurt. Then stops.

CLARA
We'll put that in the report too.

JORY
I know.

Tom sets down a ring of depot keys.

TOM
You need to decide what you're taking out by ten. I can witness the seals. I can't leave you in here.

Clara looks from the book to the request for missing elections.

CLARA
Not just the book. The whole linked series. Otherwise whoever reads it next can make the same mistake I did.

Jory counts the full cartons behind her. Nine. They will not fit on one shelf.

JORY
Before we ask for anything: my overtime. You wrote it down yesterday. Does it still get paid if this isn't clean?

Clara takes out the overtime book. Finds the signed hours.

CLARA
Lida approved actual handling time. I can't approve your employer's wages.

JORY
Then I need the signed time sheet now. Not after we save the box.

Clara tears out the duplicate and gives it to her.

JORY
Next. I don't copy a resident page onto my phone. You don't put my name against a statement you haven't shown me. Even if you're late.

CLARA
Agreed.

JORY
And if I say I'm done, it isn't your moral emergency that makes me stay.

Clara looks at Tom. He keeps taking the calendar down.

CLARA
Agreed. I need something too. If you send anything that includes the record, you tell me what and to whom. Before sending.

JORY
Yes.

CLARA
I can't put the names back. I can't protect you from that report.

JORY
I'm not asking you to. I am asking you not to use my bad choice to make every next choice for me.

Clara closes the overtime book.

CLARA
What do you want to do now?

Jory checks her phone. No new employment message.

JORY
Ask Sana. Then do the handling I'm still employed to do. At ten we stop with Tom. After that we decide again.

Clara nods. Jory writes their four terms on the back of the duplicate time sheet. Not a contract, not a reconciliation. She gives Clara a photograph of the terms alone, with no household page under it.

INT. COURIER DEPOT -- DISPATCH CAGE -- WEDNESDAY NIGHT

Sana measures the cage with the bakery ruler while Jory reads storage conditions. Clara stands outside the wire.

SANA
Nine cartons fits if the returns shelf goes. The shelf belongs to the insurer. The cage belongs to us. The lease ends next month.

CLARA
I would need six weeks.

SANA
Then it's not six weeks here.

JORY
We have an option to renew.

SANA
If we retain the route package. Which needs a clean completion. You see the circle?

Jory starts to answer, stops. Sana appreciates being spared.

CLARA
Could we rent a separate lockable bay?

SANA
You're looking at it. Everything else gets wet when the roller door lifts.

Clara reads the form again. Jory watches her, then takes it and finds the line herself: CONTINUITY OF CUSTODY THROUGH REVIEW PERIOD.

JORY
We can guarantee a month.

SANA
We can't guarantee Monday.

Sana puts a kettle on. This one works. For a moment the sound is insulting.

SANA
There is an overnight transfer slot to the municipal strongroom. We use it for ballot returns. They need a receiving officer, an itemized consignment, and a booking. If you're their records officer, ask them.

CLARA
I know that route.

Jory looks up from the conditions.

JORY
Since when?

CLARA
This morning. It needs an officer statement. I wanted to establish more before I put one in.

JORY
So I spent the afternoon looking for a cupboard because you didn't want to sign something?

CLARA
Yes.

Sana puts the ruler down.

SANA
I'm not storing it here. If the strongroom takes a declared consignment, declare it. You've both had enough favors made to look like work.

Jory folds the storage conditions. Clara takes the strongroom request out of her folder. She had kept it.

Jory takes three mugs down. Clara holds the one with a chipped handle by its bowl. No one mistakes a possible route for a solution.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- NIGHT

21:43. Tom checks seals while Clara phones the service office's recorded information line. CLOSED. She finds the transfer conditions and a duty address. Types a request.

TOM
This carton has welfare applications. They can't travel with the public works files.

CLARA
They're linked by the relocation references.

TOM
They're linked by staples. Different access rules.

He points to a medical assessment inside. Clara closes it at once.

JORY
Can you inventory them without reading them?

CLARA
Folder level. Restricted bundle inside the disputed series.

She changes her inventory headings. The nine cartons will need an internal map, not just a number.

TOM
I've got seventeen minutes.

CLARA
I know.

TOM
You keep saying that like it's more time.

Clara takes off her depot key, sets it on his calendar. Jory is startled by the surrender.

CLARA
Please witness what we have. We'll stop when you have to stop.

Tom gets the seals. They work: Clara identifies, Jory boxes, Tom witnesses. Not fast enough for nine. Fast enough for seven. Clara chooses the ledger, the receiving series and the title files, leaving two closed cartons in place with red tags.

Her phone lights: DUTY REQUEST RECEIVED. NOT AN AUTHORIZATION. She writes the message number in the inventory instead of smiling.

EXT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- YARD -- NIGHT

22:00. Tom locks the outer door. Seven disputed cartons sit in the covered loading cage, sealed in Clara's and Tom's presence. Two remain inside.

TOM
I can say those seven haven't left custody. I can't say what's in them.

CLARA
That is all I need you to say.

He hands her his witness sheet. She offers him the flask.

TOM
Keep it. Don't archive it.

He starts toward the bus stop. Jory holds up the van keys.

JORY
I'll take you.

TOM
I'm meeting someone. They'll be waiting.

He goes. Clara and Jory stand by the cage. A contractor's padlock holds the front gate; Clara's numbered seal holds the cartons.

JORY
I thought you'd keep him.

CLARA
So did he.

Clara phones Mara. It goes to voicemail. She does not leave an emergency in the silence.

CLARA
I'm late. Don't wait to eat. I have a key.

Jory folds down the passenger seat. A thin emergency blanket slips out.

CLARA
You don't have to stay.

JORY
I know. I'm calling my daughter before I decide.

She closes the van door for privacy. Clara walks beyond earshot, stopping where she can still see the seals.

INT. VAN -- DEPOT YARD -- NIGHT

Nell appears on Jory's phone, hair tied with a screwdriver. Behind her, flat-pack shelving waits to become furniture.

NELL
Did you get the letter?

JORY
No. The job is disputed.

NELL
Your job?

JORY
The job I'm doing. So, maybe mine.

Nell lowers the phone to pick up a screw. Jory waits rather than demand to be seen.

NELL
I can commute the first term.

JORY
Two buses and a train. You'd miss the early workshop.

NELL
I wouldn't if I took the six ten. I rang the college. You keep saying what I'd miss without asking them.

Jory puts her forehead against the steering wheel for a moment. Takes it away before answering.

JORY
I was trying to get you the room.

NELL
I know. I want the room. But if you're not getting the letter, I need to choose the travel pass before Friday. It's cheaper by term.

JORY
I'll pay it.

NELL
It's four hundred.

Jory moves her phone to check the banking app, then stops. Nell watches her calculation.

NELL
That's why I asked now.

JORY
The room deposit would cover most of it if they'll return it.

NELL
They won't. You sent me the terms.

Jory takes the receipt bearing THURSDAY12 from her pocket. Turns it over, finds the rent figures.

JORY
You're right. I didn't want that bit to be real yet.

NELL
I'm putting my weekend wages in for the pass. Then I want to keep the workshop trip money. Not all of it to fix the room.

JORY
Keep the trip money. We'll do the pass in two payments. I'll ask if they'll let us.

NELL
And if the bus is late, the college can let me join the second group. I asked that too.

JORY
Don't solve it for me tonight.

NELL
It's my college. I can solve my bit.

Jory nods. Nell cannot see while the phone points at the screws. Jory says yes aloud.

JORY
Yes. You can. I'll tell you what's real as soon as I know.

NELL
Are you eating?

JORY
A roll.

NELL
That's bread in a different format.

Jory laughs, almost upsetting the phone. Nell grins. Then a practical silence.

JORY
I'm sorry about the room.

NELL
I'm not giving it up until twelve tomorrow. You said that's the deadline.

They end the call. Jory writes THURSDAY 12 on the back of a receipt, separate from the town's nine.

INT. CLARA'S FLAT -- KITCHEN -- LATE NIGHT

Clara comes home for her personal papers. Mara is labeling freezer containers for herself, not for Clara.

MARA
There are two dinners in the fridge. The ones without my name.

Clara takes a folder from the cupboard. The commendation, in its frame, stands behind it. She turns it face down. Mara sees.

MARA
What happened?

CLARA
I certified things I hadn't checked. Years ago. I found the note where I stopped asking.

MARA
Will you lose your payment?

CLARA
I think it will be held. Perhaps repaid.

Mara puts a container in her cool bag. Then another. She doesn't unpack them.

MARA
What are you asking me for?

CLARA
Nothing.

Mara waits. Clara opens the personal folder: bank statements, tenancy, insurance.

CLARA
I want you to tell me I'm doing the right thing.

MARA
I can't check the papers for you.

CLARA
I know.

MARA
You can tell the truth and still be difficult to live with.

Clara almost smiles, then doesn't hide behind it.

CLARA
Will you send me the address when you arrive?

MARA
Of course.

She gives Clara one of the unmarked dinners. Clara takes it, then leaves the commendation in the cupboard with the back facing out.

EXT. BRIDGE LAYBY -- LATE NIGHT

Clara and Jory share the reheated dinner from its container. Jory uses the bakery ruler to prop a van window open.

JORY
It turns out the ruler is the only fully retained employee.

Clara's phone rings. Mina's name, from the duty request. Clara puts the call on speaker with Jory's permission.

MINA (PHONE)
I can book a disputed consignment into the service strongroom at eight thirty. Not nine cartons described as miscellaneous.

CLARA
They'll be itemized. Two cartons are still under restricted access.

MINA (PHONE)
Then they aren't in your consignment yet. You need the owner to release them and name you interim custodian. Your suspension notice came through.

CLARA
Lida has to sign.

MINA (PHONE)
The owner does. She is the delegate. I won't decide an employment dispute by taking a book through a side door.

Jory sets down her fork.

JORY
If we finish the transfer on time but mark it disputed, can the town reject the collection?

MINA (PHONE)
I can register what was received. I can't make that satisfactory to a contractor.

CLARA
Book the slot. Please.

MINA (PHONE)
Present the consignment by eight forty-five. Checking can continue after that if you're at the counter with the declared load. The nine o'clock custody deadline is still yours. Bring consent restrictions separately. No household papers to this number.

The line ends. Jory scrapes the dinner into two equal halves.

CLARA
I thought if I could find outside custody, I could keep my old certification out until I understood it.

JORY
You didn't want to understand it in public.

CLARA
No.

Jory takes her half. Clara waits for another condition.

JORY
We're still on the terms. Show me anything that names me. You can ask me to carry a statement. You can't make me sign it.

CLARA
I'll show you.

Clara takes out the draft for Lida and gives it to Jory before taking her own fork.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- LIDA'S OFFICE -- NIGHT

Lida admits Clara and Jory through a service entrance. She has removed her shoes. A heap of keys sits on the desk, each with a paper tag.

LIDA
The depot lock is the only one that looks like its label.

Clara puts down the interim-custodian form. Lida reads it without lifting her head.

LIDA
You want me to reinstate you for an hour, give you a disputed public record, and accept a statement accusing my department of false accounting.

CLARA
My statement says what I did. It will say what I found. It won't say who pasted the column. I don't know.

LIDA
You came close to saying it this afternoon.

CLARA
Yes.

Jory puts her deletion-request log beside it.

JORY
And this is what I sent. Who got it. Who says they deleted it. The two I can't trace.

LIDA
You understand the contractor will see this?

JORY
They've seen it already. They won't like seeing that I wrote it down.

Lida reads Clara's factual statement. Stops at CERTIFIED CONTENTS WITHOUT VERIFICATION.

LIDA
I can't release your bridge payment with this outstanding. That's not a threat. It's a condition in the scheme.

CLARA
Then don't release it.

Lida gets the bridge-payment form from the desk. Pushes it toward Clara with a pen.

LIDA
Write that you've been told. I won't have it become a claim that I ambushed you at the door.

Clara reads the notice. PAYMENT MAY BE HELD IN FULL; FINAL ELIGIBILITY SUBJECT TO FINDINGS.

CLARA
That's the whole gap between the pension and my rent.

LIDA
I know the scheme.

CLARA
I'm not telling you the scheme.

Lida leaves the pen on the form. Clara picks it up.

LIDA
I can sign ordinary storage tonight. No officer statement required tonight. Your complaint can proceed through the normal route. The payment would go forward unless a finding stopped it.

Clara looks at the alternative wording. It isn't obviously fraudulent. It is the safest lawful thing Lida can offer her.

CLARA
And the complaint response in six weeks could say the transfer is complete.

LIDA
It could also say reopen it.

Clara signs acknowledgment of the hold, not acceptance of a finding.

CLARA
I closed this once because later sounded like somebody else's work. I'm not doing that route.

Lida takes the signed acknowledgment. She has not been won over; she has been given something she can file.

Lida puts the form aside. Clara does not reach to retrieve it.

LIDA
I need the finance transfer instruction too. If this opens, it opens properly. No selective packet.

CLARA
Yes.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- COUNTER -- CONTINUOUS

Jory waits outside Lida's office while Clara revises the statement. Her phone displays the final offer conditions: SIGNED PREMISES CLEARANCE PLUS NORMAL CARRIER RETURN BY09:00. ALL CARRIER INCIDENTS CLOSED. PERMANENT HOURS CONDITIONAL.

She opens a message from operations: client may issue amended clearance. Once received, select NORMAL RETURN to close prior exception. Employment letter then released. She types: DOES THAT CLOSE THE DISCLOSURE INCIDENT? Deletes the question, then types it again and sends.

Lida comes to the water cooler. Sees the phone before Jory can turn it.

LIDA
They should not have worded it like that.

JORY
They worded it very clearly.

LIDA
I can certify the physical clearance was completed.

JORY
Will you do that before I decide what to carry?

Lida thinks about what she is being asked.

LIDA
Yes. If it's true.

JORY
And the dispute isn't my failure?

LIDA
The records dispute isn't a transport failure. I'll state that.

JORY
They're asking me to close all carrier incidents. I sent those names. That's a carrier incident.

LIDA
They can close their handling report. They can't close my privacy report.

JORY
So I can sign one screen and pretend you still have the other.

LIDA
You'd need to decide whether your declaration is true. I won't decide that for you.

Jory sits on the waiting bench. Her jacket catches on a metal edge; she pulls too hard and tears a seam.

JORY
I know. Everyone is very precise about what doesn't bind them.

Lida gets a stapler from the counter. Offers it. Jory takes it, staples the jacket seam shut, testing that the points face away from her arm.

LIDA
That's not a repair.

JORY
It'll do until morning.

Lida returns to the office. Jory reads the offer again, then saves it as a file instead of answering.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- LIDA'S OFFICE -- AFTER MIDNIGHT

Clara reads her new statement aloud while Lida compares it to the document copies. Jory listens from the door.

CLARA
I received a cover referring to twenty-three elections. My receiving note confirms I sought the missing attachments. I subsequently closed that request. My certification cannot establish that the households elected an alternative allowance.

LIDA
Add that no finding of individual nonpayment has been made.

CLARA
That's true.

She adds it.

LIDA
And that the reserve transfer was authorized separately. The pasted column isn't the finance authority.

CLARA
That's true too.

She adds it. Jory sees a stronger case become a less stirring story.

JORY
Are we making it so nobody did anything?

CLARA
No. So they have to find out what was done.

Lida signs a narrow authorization: ACCESS 06:30--08:30, NINE SPECIFIED CARTONS. Interim custodianship limited to registered transfer and six-week review access.

LIDA
My name will be on the finance instruction. Don't call that cooperation in your report. Call it supplied.

CLARA
All right.

Jory checks the time:00:26. An answer arrives: NORMAL RETURN CLOSES ALL JOB EXCEPTIONS. HISTORIC ISSUES TO BE DEALT WITH BY CLIENT. She calls operations. It goes to a duty voicemail.

JORY
This is Jory Senn, municipal transfer. I can complete physical delivery. I can't say the disclosure incident is resolved. Please confirm whether a normal return would declare that. I'm not withdrawing from the run.

She saves the message, attaches the deletion log to the condition report, but leaves the final return status open. Clara comes to read the incident summary when Jory asks her.

JORY
Your name's here. Check that paragraph.

Clara reads. Corrects a time from16:00 to16:40. Does not soften the account of the red completion label.

CLARA
That's right now.

Jory sends the interim report. The permanent offer remains open, waiting for the last return status.

She puts the phone face down. The water cooler empties itself with a soft gulp. Clara signs her factual statement.

EXT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- YARD -- THURSDAY BEFORE DAWN

Clara and Jory sit in the van, wrapped separately in one blanket. Neither has slept usefully. Clara's phone alarm says 05:45. She silences it before it rings twice.

JORY
We could have slept somewhere with a toilet.

CLARA
The office had a toilet.

JORY
And the woman who can stop us. Not restful.

Clara checks the sealed cage. Rain has blown under the awning. The cartons remain dry. Jory gets out and lays two empty pallets under the lowest shelf anyway.

CLARA
It won't rise that far.

JORY
That's what a pallet's for. So I don't have to guess.

Clara helps lift the shelf. They do it well now.

JORY
If the review says everyone was paid, what then?

CLARA
Then I'll have lost a great deal of money to correct my own certificate.

JORY
And I'll have lost a job.

Clara looks at her rather than at the boxes.

CLARA
Yes.

Jory wipes water off a pallet with her sleeve.

JORY
I needed you to say that once without finding a nicer ending.

A delivery truck passes without stopping. Both women turn, conditioned by years of being interrupted by engines. Then they return to the lift.

INT. BEA'S FLAT -- FRONT ROOM -- DAWN

Bea opens the door wearing a head torch. Clara stands outside with two coffees. Jory waits behind her.

BEA
I own lights. This is for the stitching.

She lets them in. On the table: a page headed RESIDENT CONTACT CONDITIONS. Some entries are ticks, some crosses. One is a question mark.

BEA
Three consent to being contacted. One only through me. One has not answered. One wants the book destroyed.

JORY
Because of the picture?

BEA
Because she doesn't want to prove her life to the town again. Before the picture too.

Clara reads the conditions. Bea takes the page away before Clara can turn it.

BEA
Ina wants the no-contact instruction delivered without a phone number. She put it through the door at five. I've not called her.

Bea produces an envelope. On it: FOR REGISTRAR ONLY. An added line in a different hand: NOT AUTHORITY FOR BEA QUILL TO ACT.

JORY
Do you want that in the contact packet?

BEA
I want her to trust me again. It's not a form they give you.

Bea puts the envelope beside the others.

CLARA
It should travel separately. The packet says you're the contact. Hers says you're not.

BEA
I can read it.

Jory waits. Doesn't take the envelope until Bea pushes it toward Clara instead.

BEA
Give it directly to Mina. No copy for me.

Clara writes a receipt for one closed envelope, not its contents. Gives it to Bea.

JORY
In my carrier list it can say external sealed submission. No household number.

CLARA
Show me before you send it.

Jory does. The safeguard takes twenty seconds. Bea watches the time it would have cost yesterday.

BEA
Names are on the back. Don't copy them into the public inventory.

CLARA
They'll be in a sealed contact bundle. I won't represent you in the review. I'll be a witness.

BEA
You've found your proper occupation.

Jory winces. Clara accepts the page.

BEA
I want to see the seals go on. I don't want to ride with a loose ledger.

JORY
There won't be a loose ledger.

Bea puts the finished sail cover in a carrier.

BEA
Then I'll come. After I leave this for collection. I said it would be ready this morning.

She hangs the carrier inside the outer door with an invoice. Clara starts to hurry her, catches herself, picks up the coffee instead.

INT. COURIER DEPOT -- DISPATCH CAGE -- EARLY MORNING

Sana finds Jory reading an email at the rota board. PROVISIONAL PERMANENT OFFER OPEN UNTIL09:00. NORMAL RETURN REQUIRED. OTHERWISE TEMPORARY ASSIGNMENT ENDS ON COMPLETION TODAY.

SANA
They haven't withdrawn it.

JORY
No. They want the normal-return screen. They've confirmed the letter will come out if I select it.

Jory forwards the email to Sana, then hands over the paper final offer.

SANA
Normal return doesn't change where the book is stored. You could finish the load and let the town keep its dispute.

JORY
It closes my disclosure incident. They won't say whether that's transport-only. I asked twice.

SANA
Then keep the replies.

JORY
If I click it, I get the letter. Nell gets the room application. We still deliver the records. It's a very easy button.

Sana takes the terminal, opens the final-status help text, reads it.

SANA
It says all carrier issues resolved. Not transport-only.

She returns the terminal. She cannot make the easy version true.

JORY
Can you keep those together?

SANA
Yes. We can dispute the reason. I can't promise a job.

JORY
I know your sentence too.

Sana hears it without defending herself. She takes a pencil from the rota board.

SANA
There are two Saturday shifts nobody wants. They don't replace a contract. Do you want first refusal?

JORY
Yes.

Sana writes Jory's name, not in the retained column, in the empty-shifts column. Jory watches the difference.

JORY
I'm still authorized for the municipal run?

SANA
Until the consignment is complete and the van is returned. They've confirmed that. They're very keen you finish.

Jory puts her terminal on the charger for thirty seconds while she fills the vehicle log. Sana gives her a second set of handling straps.

SANA
How many on the receiving end?

JORY
Not enough.

SANA
I'll come at eight. It's my own time. Just handling and witness. I'm not signing their version.

JORY
Neither am I.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- EARLY MORNING

06:30. Lida unlocks the room. The overhead lights have been isolated. Clara, Jory and Bea wear head torches. Bea's makes the only steady circle.

LIDA
Battery lamps are in the yard. No kettle, no sockets.

BEA
We brought civilization.

She holds up the coffee flask. Lida nearly asks for some, decides not to.

Clara opens the final two cartons. Housing welfare applications, relocation receipts, a separate public-works closeout file. She identifies the folder codes without opening medical envelopes. Bea watches the codes enter the list.

BEA
Where do you put people who weren't recognized as tenants?

CLARA
The disputed contact bundle. Separate from the official series.

BEA
Does separate mean lesser?

CLARA
It means nobody mistakes my index for proof they had no claim.

Bea takes a paper from her pocket: her own note of the date she handed back her keys. No official stamp. It names no other household.

BEA
This is mine. It says what I saw, not what they were entitled to.

Clara numbers the sheet BQ-01. Gives Bea a duplicate slip.

LIDA
That isn't a municipal record.

CLARA
No. The inventory will say so.

Lida watches the qualification written in full. She does not object again.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- MORNING

07:12. The public-works file contains the finance instruction, but a different total. Clara places it beside the held-balances carbon.

JORY
How much different?

CLARA
Four hundred and sixteen.

BEA
That was the interest we asked about.

LIDA
The transfer included accrued interest.

CLARA
Then these aren't payment totals. They're account totals.

Jory sees the pasted column again. SETTLED has become both less sinister and more dangerous.

JORY
So it could mean the account was settled. Not the people.

CLARA
Yes.

LIDA
That's what I said.

CLARA
You said they might have elected an allowance. There's no evidence they did. Both things belong in the report.

She adds a note: ACCOUNT RECONCILIATION DOES NOT ESTABLISH HOUSEHOLD PAYMENT. No accusation in the heading.

BEA
Will they use that to say no one lied?

CLARA
They may.

Bea looks as if she could sweep the papers off the table. Instead she takes off the head torch; the room is light enough now.

BEA
Leave it in. I don't want them finding it later and saying we hid it.

Lida signs the supplied-document list. Clara initials the new note. Jory checks that the copied figures and originals agree before putting the file into its sleeve.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- READING COUNTER -- MORNING

Bea waits while Clara copies the final inventory. The copier feeder takes two sheets at once. Clara stops it, flattens the pages, feeds them singly.

BEA
That's where I stood.

Clara looks at the visitor's side of the glass.

CLARA
When you asked about the rods.

BEA
When I asked about the compensation. The rods were because I couldn't bear to ask again.

Clara removes a jammed sheet. It tears. She lays the pieces together and makes a new copy.

CLARA
I sent you to finance.

BEA
You probably did. Everyone sent me somewhere.

Clara puts the next sheet in.

CLARA
I'm sorry.

Bea waits for the explanation that usually follows. It doesn't come.

BEA
Have you got somewhere to live?

CLARA
I have a flat. I can't afford it on the pension without the bridge payment.

BEA
Then don't wait twelve years to ask someone.

The final copy slides out. Clara checks it against the original, page by page. Bea helps by counting the pages backward, a different task rather than a duplicate.

Clara removes the PUBLIC READING ROOM sign from the glass. Bea asks for it with an open hand. Clara gives it to her.

EXT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- YARD -- MORNING

07:56. Sana arrives wearing work boots beneath an ordinary coat. Jory puts a handling strap over a carton. Sana points to a frayed edge. Jory changes it.

SANA
We aren't injuring ourselves for a historical precedent.

They load the van. Clara reads seal numbers. Bea matches them to her copy. Lida keeps the outer gate clear of an arriving contractor's car.

JORY
Seven, eight.

BEA
Eight matches.

The ninth carton has two seal impressions overlapping. Clara stops.

CLARA
The adhesive caught itself. We need a new seal. Record the old one void.

LIDA
It's legible.

CLARA
Two numbers are legible.

Lida checks her watch, takes the voided seal, signs across it. Sana checks the replacement. Sana holds the van door until the replacement number is recorded.

Jory's terminal offers NORMAL or EXCEPTION. She selects EXCEPTION. The next screen asks CLAIM OF DAMAGE? She selects NO, writes DISPUTED RECORD CUSTODY -- NO TRANSPORT DAMAGE.

SANA
Photograph the seals, not the pages.

JORY
Yes.

She photographs each closed carton. Clara gives her the linked inventory. Bea puts the contact restrictions in a separate envelope and seals it herself.

BEA
This travels in my hand.

Jory opens the passenger door for her.

INT. MUNICIPAL RECORDS DEPOT -- LEDGER ROOM -- MORNING

Clara makes the final walk with Lida. Empty shelves. The rectangle where the commendation hung. A clean patch where the blue book lay hidden.

LIDA
Your access ends when this door locks. If Mina rejects the consignment, it cannot come back here.

CLARA
I understand.

Clara places her keys on the cabinet. The saucer still steadies it.

LIDA
Take that. It's going to the scrap dealer.

Clara takes out the saucer. The cabinet rocks. She reaches to put it back, stops, takes the saucer with her.

CLARA
Will you challenge the contractor's employment decision?

LIDA
I will write that physical performance was satisfactory and the dispute wasn't caused by their staff. I don't control the employment decision.

CLARA
You do control whether they get another contract.

Lida turns from the empty shelf.

LIDA
And would you like that threat recorded?

Clara thinks about it.

CLARA
No. I'd like the employment condition recorded when you score them.

LIDA
I can do that. It won't be your score to check.

Clara puts the last condition report on the cabinet and signs. Lida signs beneath her: PHYSICAL PREMISES CLEARED. RESTRICTED SERIES TRANSFER SEPARATELY REGISTERED. The second clause is still prospective. Lida circles it for later confirmation.

They leave. Lida locks the door. Clara turns once at the sound, then catches up.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- COUNTER -- MORNING

08:31. Mina checks the consignment inventory while Jory, Sana and Bea wait beside the trolley. Clara holds the envelope containing her statement.

MINA
Nine cartons. Three access classes. Four external submissions.

CLARA
Two external submissions. The consent register isn't evidence of payment. The disclosure log is an incident record.

Mina corrects the receiving headings.

MINA
Good. Don't let me make them one thing.

She reads Lida's authorization, checks the signatures against the duty record, then calls Lida. Everyone can hear only Mina's side.

MINA
Did you authorize release of all nine? And Venn as interim custodian? Through transfer and review access only? Thank you.

She hangs up. Starts checking seals. At carton nine she stops.

MINA
This voided number isn't on the inventory total.

JORY
It's attached on the condition sheet.

MINA
Which isn't part of the declared consignment.

Clara closes her eyes for one second. Opens them.

CLARA
Then we amend the declaration. I will sign the extra sheet.

MINA
All witnesses to the seal replacement must sign.

Sana steps forward. Bea puts down her bag. Jory finds the photograph. The counter clock reads 08:39.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- COUNTER -- THURSDAY MORNING

08:42. The new condition sheet passes from Sana to Bea to Jory. Clara signs last. Mina staples it to the inventory and draws a line through the obsolete page count.

MINA
Your factual statement?

Clara hands her the envelope. Mina takes out the statement and the copies supporting it.

MINA
This covers two matters. Your certification, and the account discrepancy. They will be logged separately. Your certification statement is an officer record, not a private resident submission.

CLARA
I put it with the restricted bundle.

MINA
The household details can be restricted. Your account of your own act can't inherit their privacy.

Clara looks at the envelope. She turns it over, then puts it in the wastebasket.

MINA
You can remove their names from the officer statement. You can't remove what you did and still use the statement to establish the discrepancy.

Jory watches. There is no need to encourage Clara.

CLARA
Give me a clean copy. I'll remove the household references from that paragraph. Leave my name.

Mina copies the statement. Clara draws a line through two references, initials each change and attaches the uncensored evidentiary copy under the restricted tab.

CLARA
Does this open a compensation claim?

MINA
No. It opens a records dispute. Residents decide what to submit afterward.

Bea nods once. Clara signs the officer record where nothing remains to hide her signature.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- STRONGROOM -- MORNING

08:47. A narrow, unlovely room. Not a vault in a thriller: shelves, humidity cards, two sets of keys, a stool with a split seat.

Mina admits Clara as the interim records custodian and Jory as the carrier. Sana remains outside with Bea.

JORY
Nine. Bottom shelf. Heavy corners outward.

Clara follows her instructions. It is Jory's room until the load is safe. Mina checks every seal against the amended inventory.

MINA
I'll hold the access keys. Your name authorizes supervised retrieval during review. It doesn't authorize changes to the original series.

CLARA
I understand.

Clara places the blue book's carton on the shelf. She moves it so the spine will not bear the weight, though she can no longer see the book.

JORY
Is that all?

CLARA
That's all we declared.

Jory checks the trolley, the floor, the empty straps.

JORY
That's all we brought.

Mina writes RECEIVED 08:53. She does not write VERIFIED CONTENTS. She holds the record so Clara can read it. Clara nods.

They leave. Mina locks the room with one key, then another. Clara hears the first turn, waits for the second, and doesn't reach for either.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- COUNTER -- MORNING

08:56. Mina stamps two receipts and gives one to Clara, one to Jory. Bea receives a separate acknowledgment of the sealed contact conditions. Sana signs the handling witness sheet.

Jory enters the receipt number on her terminal. The next screen offers NORMAL RETURN or COMPLETE WITH EXCEPTION. A message arrives from operations: AMENDED CLIENT CLEARANCE ACCEPTABLE. SELECT NORMAL NOW FOR LETTER.

Jory opens NORMAL RETURN. A declaration: ALL CARRIER ISSUES RESOLVED. Above it the nine-carton receiving reference is already correct. She can keep the records safe and still press this.

Clara reaches to read. Stops short of taking the terminal.

JORY
The book gets there either way.

CLARA
Yes.

JORY
And I can't get those pictures back either way.

Clara looks toward Bea. Bea is reading her own contact receipt, not watching for a virtuous performance.

JORY
If I close it, I stop being the person who has to ask where they went.

The phone shows a new message from Nell: LETTER YET? Jory types NO. STILL FINISHING. Sends it, without photographing the screen beneath it.

She returns to status selection and chooses COMPLETE WITH EXCEPTION. The disclosure log stays attached. Below it: NO ASSURANCE OF CONTRACTUAL ACCEPTANCE.

JORY
This one leaves the incident open.

She turns the screen to Clara. Clara reads it.

CLARA
The physical delivery is complete. The record is disputed.

JORY
I wasn't asking you to sign.

Clara takes her hand away from the offered stylus. Jory signs her own carrier record, submits, waits. ACCEPTED FOR RECEIPT -- EXCEPTION OPEN.

Clara phones Lida.

CLARA
Nine received at eight fifty-three. Reference seven-four-one-six. I'm sending the receipt.

She sends it. Lida replies with a photograph of the cleared-premises certificate. The circled clause is now initialed and timed 08:58.

The clock turns nine. Nothing happens to the lights. Someone in the waiting room asks Mina about a parking permit.

BEA
Do we go now?

MINA
Yes. Keep your receipts. The review reference will follow.

Clara puts hers away. Jory holds hers a moment longer before folding it. She unfolds it again to check the exception reference.

INT. COURIER DEPOT -- DISPATCH CAGE -- LATER THAT MORNING

Jory returns the van key, handling straps and terminal. Her email now reads OFFER LAPSED: REQUIRED NORMAL RETURN NOT RECEIVED BY09:00. Sana prints it and staples it to the conditional offer.

JORY
I could have clicked it.

SANA
I know.

Sana checks off the equipment. Jory supplies the terminal before she has to ask.

SANA
Jacket's personal issue. Keep it.

JORY
They'll charge me for the staples.

Sana notices the repair. Opens a drawer. Takes out a small sewing kit.

SANA
That's mine. Return it.

Jory takes it. Her phone shows 10:17. She calls the room agent while Sana files the receipt.

JORY
It's Senn, about the room. I can't supply the permanent-employment letter. No, the deposit isn't the issue. I don't have the letter.

She listens. Looks at Nell's photograph.

JORY
If another applicant takes it, please tell me. Don't hold it on my word.

She ends the call. Sana pushes a copy of Lida's physical-performance statement through the hatch.

SANA
This came in. It goes with the two offers. We've opened the employment grievance.

JORY
Opened.

SANA
That's the word I can use.

Jory takes the Saturday rota, writes the shift time on her own calendar. Then she picks up her bag. Without the van key, she has to go out through the pedestrian door. Sana releases its sticky latch.

INT. CLARA'S FLAT -- KITCHEN -- FRIDAY MORNING

Mara checks her packed cases against a handwritten list. Clara is making toast in a pan because the buyer collected the toaster too.

MARA
You sold it before breakfast.

CLARA
They could only come early.

MARA
It's possible to say ten.

Clara turns the toast with her fingers, jerks back from the heat. Mara gives her tongs from the knife roll.

CLARA
Those are packed.

MARA
They'll pack again.

A letter lies open by the bridge-payment envelope: PAYMENT HELD PENDING FINDINGS. Clara has written a phone number beside it and an appointment time for a housing adviser.

MARA
You called?

CLARA
Eleven thirty Monday.

Mara nods. She puts the toast in foil for the train.

CLARA
I don't know if they'll pay the households.

MARA
You didn't promise me they would.

They stand with no household task between them. Clara opens her arms. Mara steps in, then has to step out to stop her suitcase rolling. Both laugh a little.

CLARA
Send the address. Not just a picture of the kitchen.

MARA
I will.

Mara takes the case through the doorway herself. Clara follows with the lighter bag. She leaves the held-payment letter on the table, where she can find it when she returns.

INT. BEA'S FLAT -- FRONT ROOM -- THE FOLLOWING WEEK

Jory has brought Sana's sewing kit to ask Bea for help before returning it. Bea inspects the repair in the courier jacket. The stitches wander but hold.

BEA
You pulled the thread too tight.

JORY
I pull most things too tight.

BEA
That isn't an instruction. Next time leave a little give.

She clips one stitch, knots the thread again. Hands the jacket back.

Clara sits at the table with the review notice. Bea has supplied biscuits, not forgiveness.

CLARA
They've appointed a reviewer from the neighboring district. She'll ask for household submissions separately. This is only notice that the record is preserved.

BEA
Will they pay for copies?

CLARA
I asked. The first set is free. Further requests are to be assessed.

BEA
There it is again. The little gate.

Clara makes a note. Bea puts a hand on it.

BEA
I'll ask. You can tell me which form.

Clara slides the notice around so Bea can read the reference herself. Jory gets a message from Nell: ROOM TAKEN. COMMUTE ROUTE WORKS. She sets the phone down.

BEA
Bad news?

JORY
One part bad. One part being sixteen and already better at timetables.

Bea pushes the biscuit plate nearer without choosing a response for her.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- COUNTER -- SIX WEEKS LATER

Lida signs a receipt for a copy of the finance-transfer instruction. Mina checks the access log. Clara waits on the public side of the counter this time.

LIDA
The reserve audit passed. They found the transfer properly authorized.

CLARA
And the households?

LIDA
Different review. No finding yet.

Mina gives Lida a copy, leaves the original in its sleeve.

LIDA
You can apply to release part of the bridge payment for living costs. Finance sent the form.

CLARA
I received it.

LIDA
Are you applying?

CLARA
Yes.

Lida puts the spare form away.

CLARA
Did the employment condition go in the contractor assessment?

LIDA
Yes. They dispute our description.

CLARA
Can Jory have the description?

LIDA
She has it. Sana asked before you did.

Clara nods. Lida almost smiles. Mina calls the next number. Both women step aside.

MINA
Reading room's ready. Forty minutes. Pencils on the writing table. No pens by the document tray.

Clara puts her pen in her handbag. Lida takes her copy and leaves for an office that still exists.

EXT. BRIDGE LAYBY -- SATURDAY DAWN

Jory waits with Nell for an early bus. Nell carries a workshop case; Jory wears the repaired jacket. A different courier van passes. It doesn't stop.

NELL
You start at seven?

JORY
Sorting. No van today.

NELL
I can get you from the depot after. If I catch the early train back.

JORY
Stay for the workshop. I'll get the bus.

Nell adjusts Jory's torn seam. It now lies flat.

NELL
Did the grievance people answer?

JORY
They say there'll be a meeting. No date.

NELL
Does that mean no?

JORY
No date. Sana's chasing.

The bus appears. Jory takes a folded note from her bag: the old rental-room dimensions. She starts to throw it away, then uses the blank reverse to write Nell's return service.

NELL
I have it on my phone.

JORY
I haven't.

Nell lets her keep it. They board through separate doors, Nell flashing a student pass, Jory counting coins that the driver doesn't rush her to count. Through the glass, the floodwall follows the bus toward town.

INT. MUNICIPAL SERVICE OFFICE -- TEMPORARY READING ROOM -- MORNING

A folding table, two chairs, a cupboard locked by Mina. Bea places the old PUBLIC READING ROOM sign upright against the wall. It is too large for the space.

Clara opens a supervised copy of the blue ledger. The original paste remains on the original, under restricted custody. In this copy an added slip reads: ACCOUNT RECONCILED. INDIVIDUAL ELECTIONS AND PAYMENTS NOT ESTABLISHED BY THIS RECORD.

BEA
Ina's niece wants to submit her own account. Ina still doesn't.

CLARA
They can make separate statements.

BEA
Same household.

CLARA
Different people.

Bea takes two request forms. Clara starts putting household numbers on them, then stops. Slides the blank forms across.

BEA
What are you writing?

Clara shows her own statement, returned with questions in the margin. One asks WHY REQUEST CLOSED. In pencil she has written: I WANTED THE PERMANENT POST. The next line is blank.

CLARA
They asked what I thought would happen to the missing forms.

BEA
What did you think?

CLARA
That the housing office would still have a way to deal with it.

BEA
You told me you knew it had closed.

Clara draws a line through the sentence she has begun below the answer. Does not erase it.

CLARA
I knew it. I let myself use it anyway.

Bea takes her pencil.

BEA
Put that.

Clara writes: I USED AN OFFICE I KNEW HAD CLOSED AS MY REASON NOT TO ASK AGAIN. She leaves the question about exact date unanswered.

Bea turns to her own forms. The closed envelope from Ina is logged on the contact list as delivered separately. It is not among Bea's papers.

The table rocks as both women begin. Clara takes the depot saucer from her bag, bends to put it under the leg. Bea lifts the table a little so Clara can reach.

The table steadies. Clara straightens, finds the blank space, and starts writing. Beside her, Bea writes a different account.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END